

network of over 30,000 km of roads. We have made a plan to provide road connectivity to every village in the state having a population of 500 or above by the end of this year. For such areas where road construction is not possible we are connecting them by 'Gram path' for which 'Mukhya Mantri Gram Path Yojna' is being implemented. Besides, efforts are also afoot to improve the existing roads in a time bound manner.

■ **While pursuing development, how are you keeping the balance with environmental protection?**

Environment preservation and protection is our priority. We are setting up only those industrial units and other projects in the State, which are environment friendly. We have banned the use of polythene in the State. We have been awarded Diamond State Award for environment conservation. We have put up complete ban on green felling. Our efforts in implementation of the Mid-Himalayan Watershed Management Programme have been appreciated by the World Bank in its report published in the recent past. We have organised a conclave of the Chief Ministers of the Himalayan States recently which has come out with Shimla Declaration for preserving the Himalayas and meet the Climate Challenges.

■ **Finally, are there any problems that you are facing where you think the Centre could be more helpful?**

Yes, the Central Government should appreciate the developmental needs of the State and provide liberal assistance to carry out developmental programmes as development cost in Himachal Pradesh is much higher in comparison to other states. Himachal Pradesh has been contributing significantly for the environment protection by putting complete ban on green felling. The Centre should compensate the State for this as the whole country benefits from this and it should clear other projects of the State such as expansion of the rail network. The Centre should also recognise the contribution we have made to the defence services and the criteria of population for recruitment to Indian Armed Force in respect of Himachal Pradesh should be relaxed by the Central Government. Besides, the industrial package given by the NDA Government and later on reduced by the UPA Government should be extended up to 2013 as decided by the previous NDA Government. The Centre should also give approval to the state for levy of generation tax on power projects as given for Thermal power projects. This will help the state to raise resources for development.



HIMACHAL'S CONCERN FOR ENVIRONMENT

Himachal Pradesh has taken effective steps for conservation and preservation of environment and its efforts have been recognised at the national level. It has got the Diamond State Award for environment conservation.

- Amongst the first States in the Country to ban the use of recycled polythene in 1999. In 2004, we partially banned the use of polythene carry bags of specialised category. Now w.e.f. Oct 2, 2009 we are completely banning the use of plastic carry bags and at the same time also strengthening the management of our Municipal Solid Waste Management Systems. We have also taken initiative for co-processing of plastic waste in cement kilns and use of plastic waste in road construction.
- We have made it mandatory for all existing and upcoming hydel projects to release prescribed minimum water immediately downstream of the diversion structures, equivalent to 15 per cent of the minimum inflow observed in the lean season discharge, for the maintenance of riverine ecology. Further, these projects are also required to install real-time online continuous flow measurement and data logging device(s) by December 31, 2009.
- The Government has taken a lead by involving the public at all levels and environment protection has become an integral part of the development process. Himachal is the first state in the country to initiate processes to achieve carbon neutrality. We have initiated 'Community Led Assessment, Awareness, Advocacy and Action Programme (CLAP)' for environment protection and carbon neutrality, which is community driven and implemented through eco-clubs, NGOs, and panchayats.
- We are amongst the first states in the country to initiate process of rain water harvesting in all buildings.
- We encourage run of river hydel power projects and are striving to meet 100 per cent energy requirement from the hydel sector.
- We have initiated process of energy efficiency, waste audit and water audit. We are promoting use of energy-efficient devices and making efforts to reduce the consumption of energy and promoting use of solar passive technologies. The solar passive designs have been made mandatory in the state.
- We are undertaking afforestation measures and promoting conservation of natural resources.
- We are discouraging use of fossil fuels and other traditional materials for space heating and have banned use of coal for space heating purposes.
- We have constituted 'Himachal Pradesh Environment Fund' for creating a corpus for environmental protection works.
- Himachal has also set up Common Treatment and Storage and Disposal Facility (TSDF) for hazardous waste management in the State.
- The State Government is moving further ahead on its agenda of reducing Green House Gas (GHG) emissions and has now also constituted 'State Level Governing Council' and the 'State Level Steering Committee' to monitor the targets, objectives and achievements of the 8 National Missions on Climate Change set by the Union of India.
- The State Government has introduced CFL for energy conservation through the 'Atal Biji Bachat Yojna' by distributing 4 CFL bulbs free of cost to every family in Himachal Pradesh.
- Himachal has embarked on a unique initiative of preparing an 'Environment Master Plan' for the state, wherein the spatial vulnerability assessment would be undertaken and it will also lead to development of sectoral guidelines for environmental protection.
- The unique Mid-Himalayan Watershed Project has been started with the assistance of the World Bank which will harness revenues through carbon credits for Panchayats and local communities.
- The State Government through E-Samadhan has provided a portal for redressal of public grievances pertaining to environment and pollution. The H.P. State Pollution Control Board has also started a web enabled 'consent mechanism' named as 'HimXGN' which has resulted in functional efficiency, transparency and accountability.
- Hosted the first 'Himalayan Chief Ministers' Conclave -- Indian Himalayas: glaciers, climate change and livelihoods' at Shimla, which has resulted in 'Shimla Declaration on Sustainable Himalayan Development' which contain initiatives such as establishment of a Himalayan Sustainable Development Forum, setting up of State Councils for Climate Change, catalysing research for policy action and payment for ecosystem services.